

Smetana's birthplace. Until 1831, his family lived in a ground-floor apartment in the castle brewery, where his father was brewer to Count Waldstein.

Return to Prague

The Czech National Revival (see [box](#)) persuaded Smetana, who had remarried after his wife's death, to return home in 1862. He became conductor of Prague's new Provisional Theater—founded as a home for Czech opera—in 1866, and worked to develop its repertoire of Czech operas. Having been brought up speaking German, he now learned the Czech language, and set it with great eloquence in his mature operas. Over the next 20 years, he completed eight magnificent works based on national legend or comic tales, *The Bartered Bride* (1866), *Dalibor* (1867), and *The Kiss* (1876) among them.

However, numerous conservative critics disapproved of Smetana's Wagner-influenced style and tried to subvert his position. He resisted the campaign for his dismissal, but was forced to resign in 1874 after suffering from the onset of syphilis. That fall he became totally deaf.

Over the next few years, Smetana worked on six symphonic poems intended to embody the spirit of Czech nationalism. The cycle, *Má vlast* (My Homeland), first performed in 1882, became an emblem of Czech resurgence. Professional success countered the composer's depression and distracted him from great physical pain. Smetana's *String Quartet No. 2 in D minor* (1882–1883) may reflect his disturbed state of mind; certainly his physical and mental decline caused him to suffer immensely, provoking